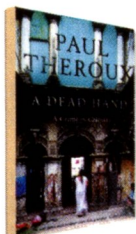


A Crime in FICTION

An overdose of neo-Orientalist stereotypes paralyses Theroux's new Calcutta novel



**A DEAD HAND:
A CRIME IN
CALCUTTA**

by PAUL THEROUX
Hamish Hamilton

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| By Brinda Bose |

The overriding irony about *A Dead Hand* is not that the title plays itself out both literally and metaphorically in the novel (yes, it is both about that body part of a corpse as well as about writer's block). The irony, instead, is that the novel is mostly about a pair of very live hands, female hands that are so adept at (a)rousing "tantric massages" on an ageing pink male *firangee* body that they transport its owner into an endless pre-coital heaven of anticipatory bliss: a bliss that clouds his mind and confuses his senses so completely that the plot appears to swiftly lose its way in tracking "a crime in Calcutta" and becomes, indeed, a rather-thinly-disguised apology for a lonely, middle-aged, male writer's sad search for a reason to rise and shine each day in an alarmingly-indifferent Third World city that fails to inspire either his pen or his "wand of light". Ugh.

Here is, alas, a novel in which Paul Theroux, redoubtable author of 31 travel fictions of one kind

or another, appears to be lost even before he has laid out a map. And laid out, one may say with a shudder, is where we mostly are in this journey, from one experience of a naked man lying prone on a hot-oil-slicked wooden table being worked upon by powerful female fingers pressing down to his very bones, to another in which the tables are figuratively turned so that he can now demonstrate to his benefactress that not only has he absorbed such delicious sensations as she has deigned to bestow on his hitherto-flaccid anatomy—but has also learnt his lessons well enough to return her favours with pleasure, gratitude and mostly undisguised lust.

What is almost embarrassing about *A Dead Hand: A Crime in Calcutta* is that it seems to try so pathetically hard to be what it never can be: a complex post-modern crime drama that is also an intellectual pirouette on writing itself. And so we have as male protagonist, a travel writer with writer's block, Jerry Delfont, who is clearly a Theroux prototype—except that somewhere in the midst of Delfont's struggles as self-flagellating writer, self-congratulatory tantric masseur and intrepid detective of crime, Theroux himself pops up in the tale in a cameo flashpoint. This is potentially the most promising moment of the novel—when meeting a doppelganger may have yielded insights both disturbing and transformative—but Theroux as the producer of this imagined encounter unwittingly fails to cash in on his own guest appearance, and the brightest chance to redeem an otherwise unwise intrigue (and the ultimate Calcutta crime) is forever lost.

Delfont is not, however, the centre of this intrigue but merely its facilitator; his sole function in the novel appears to be to periodically and pitifully bemoan the double-entendre of "dead hands" that are strewn through its plot (his own, unable to write until brought to life again by a lady's magic fingers, and a dismembered corpse's, horrifyingly turning up in his hands, literally, to impel him toward passionate crime-solving). The lady, Merrill Unger, an alluringly sensual fellow middle-aged twice-divorced American whose philanthropic mask Delfont is unable to see through for the fog of steamy sexual promise that she whips up to sidetrack him, is a dismal critique of First World exploitation of Third World

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